



Yibbi Jansen, instrumental in her team's gold medal defence at Paris 2024, was named FIH 2024 Player of the Year.



watching the Netherlands blow Great Britain away, winning by a 9-2 margin in the men's hockey Olympic semifinal. The atmosphere was electric, the thrill unmatched. Yibbi started missing it from the very moment she left the United Kingdom. Her mother eventually played the role of Good Samaritan, helping to get Ronald on board with the idea.

Thus began a long and arduous journey. By the age of 15, Yibbi had already debuted for HC Den Bosch in the Hoofdklasse Dames, the highest level of club hockey in the Netherlands.

And in her very first season, she won the club championship. However, she made a surprise switch to mid-table side Oranje-Rood the following season, feeling that she couldn't fully develop her skills at her

previous club, which was filled with superstars.

Finally, on January 28, 2018, Yibbi earned her senior national cap. At that moment, she felt everything was falling into place.

"When I was 18, I played for the Dutch team for the first time. In the first year, you love everything. You tend to enjoy everything," she told *Sportstar* on the sidelines of the inaugural edition of the Women's Hockey India League (HIL-W), where her services were acquired for a whopping Rs 29 lakh by Odisha Warriors. The bid made her the most expensive foreign player of HIL-W.

She began featuring consistently in the orange shirt thereafter. She played her first international tournament in China, where the Dutch team decimated the then Olympic gold medallist, Great Britain,

4-0 on its way to winning the Champions Trophy title. In 2019, she tasted success again, as the Dutch side won the first edition of the FIH Women's Pro League.

She found herself between a rock and a hard place when her form dipped in the following months. Despite making the initial 22-member squad for the Tokyo Olympics, which was announced in 2019, she couldn't board the flight to the pandemic-delayed Games in 2021.

"When the harder years came, I had a tough time merely getting selected for tournaments. I was not good enough at that time. They (the Netherlands) didn't drop me, but it was worse that I wasn't able to play despite being with them. That's not a nice feeling. So later, I just decided to drop myself and take some time off.